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Cover story UNDERAGE SEX



Who made the first move?

ME 44

PARTNER 56

Male 71, Female 10

Male 29, Female 90

For 3,923 respondents of the total of 5,353 who have had sex. All figures in per cent.

Women tend to be less frank about their first sexual encounter. While 70 per cent men in Bangalore had talked about it, the highest for women was 44 per cent in Ludhiana.

for thousands of years. Time was, when Indian parents controlled children with an iron rod. But in a world where families spend "quality time" at the mall and parents bend themselves backward to provide children with every advantage—cell phones with the latest bells, all the way to a thick pay packet for that elite college abroad—teenage has taken on a whole new meaning. They have more money, more choice, more knowledge and more know-how than ever before. And nowhere is this more obvious than in the way they are expressing their sexuality. As Dr M.K.C. Nair, who heads the Indian Academy of Paediatrics, points out: out of 100 teenage girls in a big-city school, at least 15 are sexually experienced, 25 sexually active, eight seek out doctors and two encounter sexual abuse.

When did it all start? The year was 2004, when a sex clip, passed around by a bragging schoolboy to his friends, made its way to video disc-sellers in

Delhi. It did not draw much attention until an IT student booked it for sale on an Internet auction. The MMS scandal and the unapologetic hero and heroine of the moment sent shock waves in urban India. But it was hardly a one-off. The year before, doctors at Delhi's Max Hospitals had reported a peaking of pregnancy queries and of adolescents seeking abortion. In 2005, the nation was shaken up when two small-town girls in Uttar Pradesh spectacularly eloped to get married to each other and another lesbian couple tried to commit suicide. In 2006, the National AIDS Control Organisation reported that a third of AIDS infections across India were in the 15-29 age group. Yet in 2007, the nation broke out in a sweat over the introduction of sex education in schools, as state after state found the course material "disgraceful and capable of corrupting the minds of the young". That very year, the first Indian "condom disco" opened inside